

Q How much use is an exercise ball? Is it worthwhile to invest in one?

An exercise ball can be a valuable aid during labor, and it can help you perform exercises in pregnancy to prepare you for the birth. It also provides an alternative support if you find sitting uncomfortable or have poor posture.

Despite their name, exercise balls are also used as birthing balls, made of tough material—although some exercise balls have the advantage of a nonslip finish. It's worth buying an exercise ball early on if you do buy one, since it can be used for back support and as a base for both prenatal and postpartum exercise. If you choose to buy one, make sure you buy a ball that is at least 26in (65cm) in diameter, or 30in (75cm) if you are taller (5ft 9in/1.75m or more).

Comfortable exercise

Sitting on the ball while you are pregnant can help with your posture, since you need to sit straight and upright to maintain your balance without curving your back, which in turn helps to strengthen the muscles in your back and prevent backaches. You can practice Kegel floor exercises (see p.67) while sitting on the ball, and perform gentle pelvis exercises (see below) during pregnancy and after the birth. Finding your balance on the

ball can be tricky as first, so ask someone to help you sit down and get up until you feel confident doing this yourself. Use the ball on carpet rather than a smooth surface for stability.

In late pregnancy, when it can be difficult to sit comfortably, an exercise ball provides a supportive base that may be more comfortable than a chair. You may find that it is easier to get into a standing position from a ball than from a chair. You also naturally lean slightly forward when sitting on an exercise ball, which helps to move your baby into a good position before labor (see p.199).

During the first stage of labor, sitting on an exercise ball can help you stay upright and active (see p.210) and allow you to rock your pelvis, which can help to shift your baby into a good position for the delivery. After the birth, an exercise ball may be more comfortable to sit on if you have stitches, and can provide a good route back into a gentle exercise regimen.

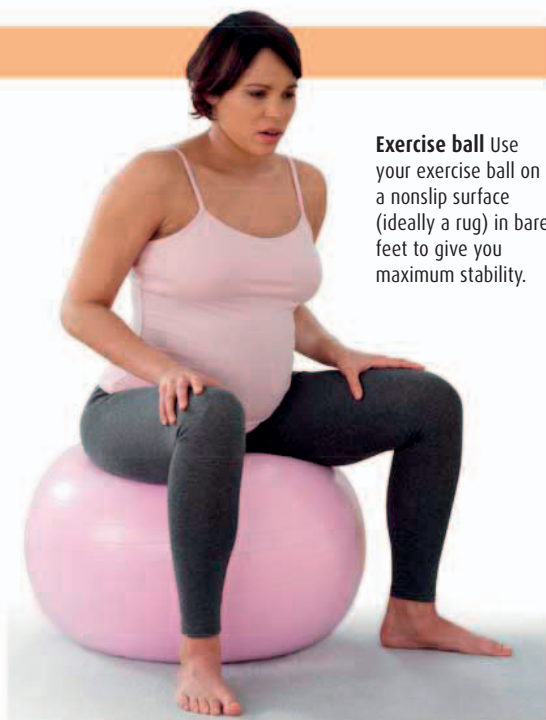
EXERCISE BALL USES

An exercise ball can prove useful not just for labor, but throughout pregnancy and after the birth, too.

» **Sitting:** sit with your knees and feet apart so you feel balanced and stable. Keep your feet flat on the floor, your back straight, and your shoulders pulled back and down with your hands on your knees.

» **Pelvis exercises:** rotate your pelvis clockwise a few times, and then counterclockwise. Connect them by moving your pelvis in figure-eight movements. Then practice your Kegel exercises.

» **Labor:** gently rock your pelvis as you sit on the ball. If kneeling down feels easier during contractions, lean against the ball and wrap your arms around it for support.



Exercise ball Use your exercise ball on a nonslip surface (ideally a rug) in bare feet to give you maximum stability.

Tips for backaches

» In addition to using support aids to relieve back pain, regular gentle exercise will keep you fit and supple and help to strengthen your back and muscles. Try swimming, pregnancy yoga, or simple strengthening exercises (see p.65).

» A firm mattress will provide important support while you sleep. If your mattress sags and you're not planning on buying a new one soon, try putting a hard board under it to make it firm.

» Try an exercise ball (see left), which will help you sit straight and ease back pain.

Q What can I use to support my back during the day? I'm getting some lower back pain as my belly grows.

There are a few support aids you can try, including a pregnancy belt and a lumbar support cushion. A soft, durable pregnancy belt helps to make your pelvic area more stable and support your abdomen and back. It is designed to be adjustable and fit under your belly, helping to lift and support your expanding uterus and, in turn, take the pressure off your back, relieving hip pain. Many women find these support belts helpful if they are on their feet or walking for any length of time.

Use a cushion to support your lower back when sitting in a chair or your car. Special lumbar support cushions mold to the shape of your lower back when you sit, improving your posture by stopping you from sinking into the seat, and relieving stress on your back ligaments.

A soft mattress can exacerbate your back pain. Use a firmer mattress if you can, or place a board under your soft mattress.

Back pain is up there with the most common complaints in pregnancy, with almost three quarters of women complaining of a backache at some point. See p.138 for more information on back pain while pregnant. Pregnancy-related pelvic girdle pain (PPGP) also causes pain in the lower back (see page 133 for advice). Let your doctor know about your back pain, too, since he or she may be able to refer you for obstetric physical therapy.